



Prepared by the Clerk
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Who's paying to blow up the party primary?

Nearly a thousand bills in 52 legislatures since 2009 — and just thirteen became law. Then a handful of billionaires poured tens of millions into 2024 ballot measures to throw the primaries open, and voters said no almost everywhere. The whole fight, on the record.

339

bills on primary access
since 2009, 52
jurisdictions

277

would let more voters
into a primary

62

would narrow who may
vote

13

passed a legislature

Key takeaways

- **Almost nothing passes.** 947 bills since 2009 touched who may vote in a primary. Thirteen became law. Changing a primary is one of the hardest things to move through a statehouse.
- **The money is a network, not a movement.** One set of donors — Unite America, the Arnolds' Action Now, Katherine Gehl, Kenneth Griffin — bankrolled the 2024 ballot measures: about \$29M in Nevada, \$15M in Colorado. Both lost.
- **Voters keep saying no.** Every 2024 measure to open a primary failed except in the District of Columbia. In Alaska the reform side outspent a repeal a hundred to one and still won by only 664 votes.

The short version

- Since 2009 the record holds **339 bills** in 43 states, the District of Columbia and Congress that would open, half-open or close a primary: 277 that widen who may vote and 62 that narrow it. A further 481 bills concern ranked-choice voting, the reform most often bundled with an open primary.
- **13 of them passed.** Most of the rest never left committee. The pattern is the same in nearly every state: the bill is filed, referred, and refiled the next session.
- The two changes that mattered most in the last five years both came through legislatures, not ballot measures: **Maine** (LD 231, 2022, in force 2024) and **New Mexico** (SB 16, signed April 7, 2025, in force 2026) let unaffiliated voters into party primaries.
- The ballot-measure route ran the other way in 2024. Top-two, top-four or top-five proposals failed in Alaska (a repeal that fell short), Arizona, Colorado, Idaho, Montana, Nevada and South Dakota; only the District of Columbia's Initiative 83 passed.

- **Louisiana** is the one state moving toward closed primaries by statute: party primaries for Congress and three statewide boards begin in 2026, and the 2026 session is filling in the mechanics.
- In Congress the idea has never left committee: the Open Our Democracy Act (2014, 2015), the CLEAN Elections Act (four Congresses) and the Let America Vote Act, H.R. 155 of the 119th Congress, sponsored by Rep. Brian Fitzpatrick with five cosponsors and referred on January 3, 2025.
- **Where the fight was expensive, it was the 2024 ballot measures, not the bills.** Reform was bankrolled by a small set of national donors and their vehicles — Unite America, Article IV, the Arnold network's Action Now, and Katherine Gehl — and still lost almost everywhere. Nevada's Question 3 drew about \$29M, Colorado's Proposition 131 about \$15M, and Alaska's defenders of reform outspent a shoestring repeal a hundred to one and won by 664 votes.

How each state runs its primaries today

A reader needs the baseline before the bills make sense. This table is the Clerk's understanding of current law in September 2026, drawn from statute and the 2024 ballot results, not from the bill record below. Verify a row before citing it; three of these changed in the last eighteen months.

State	Primary	Notes
Alabama	Open	Any voter picks a party ballot at the polls.
Alaska	Top-four, ranked-choice general	Ballot Measure 2 (2020). The 2024 repeal measure failed by fewer than 800 votes.
Arizona	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters may choose a party primary ballot. A 2024 top-two measure, Prop 140, failed.
Arkansas	Open	Voter chooses a ballot at the polls.
California	Top-two	Proposition 14 (2010), placed on the ballot by SCA 4 (2009).
Colorado	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters receive both ballots and return one (Prop 108, 2016). A 2024 top-four measure, Prop 131, failed.
Connecticut	Semi-closed	Parties may admit unaffiliated voters; neither major party does.
Delaware	Closed	Party registration required.
Florida	Closed	Party registration required; a race with one party's candidates only is opened to all.
Georgia	Open	Voter chooses a ballot at the polls.
Hawaii	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately.
Idaho	Party's choice	Republican primary closed since 2011; Democratic primary open. A 2024 top-four measure, Prop 1, failed.
Illinois	Open, public declaration	Voter asks for a party ballot on the record.
Indiana	Open, public declaration	Voter asks for a party ballot on the record.
Iowa	Open, registration at polls	A voter may change party registration at the primary.

State	Primary	Notes
Kansas	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters may affiliate at the polls.
Kentucky	Closed	Party registration required.
Louisiana	Split	Open (jungle) primary for state and local offices; closed party primaries for Congress, the Supreme Court, BESE and the PSC from 2026 under Act 1 of the 2024 First Extraordinary Session.
Maine	Semi-open	Unenrolled voters vote in a party primary of their choice, LD 231 (2022), first used in 2024.
Maryland	Closed	Party registration required.
Massachusetts	Semi-open	Unenrolled voters choose a party ballot.
Michigan	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately.
Minnesota	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately.
Mississippi	Open	Voter chooses a ballot at the polls.
Missouri	Open	Voter chooses a ballot at the polls. Amendment 7 (2024) bars ranked-choice voting.
Montana	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately. A 2024 top-four measure, CI-126, failed.
Nebraska	Semi-open; nonpartisan legislature	Unaffiliated voters may vote in some party primaries; legislative primaries are nonpartisan top-two.
Nevada	Closed	Party registration required. Question 3 (top-five with ranked-choice) failed in 2024.
New Hampshire	Semi-open	Undeclared voters pick a party ballot and may return to undeclared.
New Jersey	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters may affiliate at the polls.
New Mexico	Semi-open from 2026	SB 16 (2025) lets voters registered with no major party vote in a primary of their choice.
New York	Closed	Party enrollment required, with an early deadline.
North Carolina	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters choose a party ballot.
North Dakota	Open	No party registration at all.
Ohio	Open, public declaration	Voter asks for a party ballot on the record.
Oklahoma	Party's choice	Democrats admit independents; Republicans do not.
Oregon	Closed	Party registration required. A 2024 ranked-choice measure, M117, failed.
Pennsylvania	Closed	Party registration required. Bills to admit independents have been filed every session since 2017.
Rhode Island	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters choose a party ballot and are then affiliated unless they disaffiliate.
South Carolina	Open	Voter chooses a ballot at the polls.
South Dakota	Party's choice	Democrats admit independents; Republicans do not. A 2024 top-two measure, Amendment H, failed.

State	Primary	Notes
Tennessee	Open with a bona fide test	Voter chooses a ballot; the party may challenge a voter who is not a bona fide member.
Texas	Open	Voter chooses a ballot and is affiliated for that cycle.
Utah	Party's choice	Republican primary closed to party members; Democratic primary open.
Vermont	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately.
Virginia	Open	Voter chooses a ballot; parties may instead nominate by convention.
Washington	Top-two	Initiative 872 (2004), in use since 2008.
West Virginia	Semi-open	Unaffiliated voters may choose a party ballot where the party allows; both major parties do.
Wisconsin	Open	Voter chooses a ballot privately.
Wyoming	Closed in effect	A 2023 law ends party changes before the primary, closing the crossover route.
District of Columbia	Semi-open with ranked choice, from 2026	Initiative 83 (2024).

What the record shows, state by state

Bills whose title or summary would change who may vote in a primary, by state, across every session the record holds. "Widen" counts bills that open a primary, adopt a top-two or top-four system, or admit unaffiliated voters; "narrow" counts bills that close a primary or add a party-membership test. Ranked-choice bills are counted separately because most of them do not touch primary access. Sessions run from the first session in which the state filed such a bill to the latest.

State	Primary today	Widen	Narrow	RCV	Sessions	Furthest a bill got
Alabama	Open	4	–	2	2015 to 2018	–
Alaska	Top-four, ranked-choice general	6	–	2	2011-2012 to 2023-2024	–
Arizona	Semi-open	4	1	6	2012 to 2026	–
Arkansas	Open	2	–	1	2013 to 2017	–
California	Top-two	1	–	1	2009-2010	SCA4 (2009-2010) Signed by Governor
Colorado	Semi-open	1	–	1	2011	–
Connecticut	Semi-closed	6	–	22	2011 to 2025	–
Delaware	Closed	2	–	–	2021-2022 to 2023-2024	–
Florida	Closed	3	–	1	2015 to 2023	–
Georgia	Open	–	1	2	2025-2026	–
Hawaii	Open	10	4	45	2010 to 2016	–
Idaho	Party's choice	2	3	1	2011 to 2022	H0351 (2011) Signed by Governor
Illinois	Open, public declaration	22	–	14	2009-2010 to 2025-2026	–
Indiana	Open, public declaration	–	5	7	2010 to 2025	–
Iowa	Open, registration at polls	–	–	5	–	–
Kansas	Semi-open	–	–	3	–	–
Kentucky	Closed	3	–	3	2011 to 2023	HB150 (2015) Signed by Governor
Louisiana	Split	5	1	1	2010 to 2026	SCR55 (2020) Passed
Maine	Semi-open	13	–	28	2013-2014 to 2025-2026	LD390 (2025-2026) Passed
Maryland	Closed	9	–	19	2018 to 2026	–
Massachusetts	Semi-open	–	–	40	–	–

State	Primary today	Widen	Narrow	RCV	Sessions	Furthest a bill got
Michigan	Open	–	1	7	2013-2014	–
Minnesota	Open	–	–	48	–	–
Mississippi	Open	56	–	4	2010 to 2026	–
Missouri	Open	3	8	7	2012 to 2024	–
Montana	Open	4	–	2	2013 to 2025	SB408 (2013) Passed
Nebraska	Semi-open; nonpartisan legislature	2	–	2	2013 to 2015	–
Nevada	Closed	–	–	–	–	–
New Hampshire	Semi-open	1	2	11	2022 to 2026	–
New Jersey	Semi-open	14	1	19	2010-2011 to 2026-2027	A3820 (2022-2023) Passed
New Mexico	Semi-open from 2026	15	–	1	2012 to 2025	SB16 (2025) Signed by Governor
New York	Closed	10	15	23	2013-2014 to 2025-2026	–
North Carolina	Semi-open	2	–	–	2017-2018 to 2019-2020	–
North Dakota	Open	–	–	3	–	–
Ohio	Open, public declaration	1	–	3	2025-2026	–
Oklahoma	Party's choice	6	–	2	2011 to 2026	–
Oregon	Closed	2	–	10	2017 to 2019	–
Pennsylvania	Closed	17	–	7	2007-2008 to 2017-2018	–
Rhode Island	Semi-open	2	–	15	2020	–
South Carolina	Open	4	14	4	2023-2024 to 2025-2026	–
South Dakota	Party's choice	2	–	2	2010 to 2011	HB1054 (2010) Signed by Governor
Tennessee	Open with a bona fide test	7	–	2	2023-2024 to 2025-2026	–
Texas	Open	6	–	–	2013 to 2025	–
Utah	Party's choice	–	–	5	–	–
Vermont	Open	1	–	14	2025-2026	–
Virginia	Open	6	6	22	2012 to 2026	–
Washington	Top-two	1	–	4	2009-2010	–
West Virginia	Semi-open	3	–	12	2025 to 2026	–

State	Primary today	Widen	Narrow	RCV	Sessions	Furthest a bill got
Wisconsin	Open	4	–	11	2021-2022 to 2023-2024	–
Wyoming	Closed in effect	4	–	3	2011 to 2023	–
District of Columbia	Semi-open with ranked choice, from 2026	2	–	11	2013-2014 to 2025-2026	–

States with no qualifying bill on the record since 2009: Iowa, Kansas, Massachusetts, Minnesota, Nevada, North Dakota, Utah.

What passed

Bills in the widen-or-narrow set recorded as passed, signed or enrolled. The list is short, and it is the whole list; a handful of false matches (a Hawaiian trustee election, a certificate-of-need act) have been removed by hand.

State	Bill	Session	Title	Status
California	SCA4	2009-2010 Regular Session	Elections: open primaries.	Signed by Governor 2009-02-19
South Dakota	HB1054	2010 Regular Session	Provide independent voters voting absentee the appropriate ballot during a primary election and to declare an emergency.	Signed by Governor 2010-03-29
Louisiana	HB292	2010 Regular Session	Provides for an open primary system of elections for congressional offices (EGF SEE FISC NOTE GF EX)	Passed 2010-06-25
Idaho	H0351	2011 Regular Session	Adds to and amends existing law relating to elections to revise provisions relating to mail ballot precincts, to provide provisions relating to electo	Signed by Governor 2011-04-13
Montana	SB408	2013 Regular Session	Referendum to provide top two primary in certain elections	Passed 2013-04-23
Kentucky	HB150	2015 Regular Session	AN ACT relating to elections.	Signed by Governor 2015-03-30
Louisiana	SCR55	2020 Regular Session	Establishes the Closed Party Primary Task Force to study the necessary steps to develop a closed party primary election system applicable at the feder	Passed 2020-05-15
Maine	LD231	2021-2022 Regular Session	An Act To Establish Open Primaries	Passed 2022-04-25
New Jersey	A3820	2022-2023 Regular Session	Prohibits unaffiliated mail-in voters from receiving mail-in ballot for primary election; requires election officials to provide such voters certain n	Passed 2022-07-28
New Jersey	A1486	2024-2025 Regular Session	Changes deadline for unaffiliated mail-in voters to declare their political party before primary election.	Passed 2024-01-09
New Jersey	S3758	2022-2023 Regular Session	Changes deadline for unaffiliated mail-in voters to declare their political party before primary election.	Passed 2024-01-16
New Mexico	SB16	2025 Regular Session	Non-major Party Voters In Primary Elections	Signed by Governor 2025-04-07
Maine	LD390	2025-2026 Regular Session	An Act to Establish a Primary Election Period for Unenrolled Candidates in Order to Receive Campaign Contributions in Amounts Equal to Amounts Allowed	Passed 2025-05-27

Reading the list. California's SCA 4 (2009) is the legislative act that put Proposition 14, the top-two primary, before voters in June 2010. Louisiana's HB 292 (2010) restored the open primary for congressional seats after a two-year experiment with closed ones. Maine's LD 231 (2022) admitted unenrolled voters and was first used in 2024. New Mexico's SB 16 (2025) does the same from 2026. New Jersey's paired bills (2024) only moved the deadline by which an unaffiliated mail voter must pick a party. Idaho's H 351 (2011) is the law that closed the Republican primary after the party won the right to do so in federal court. New Jersey's A 3820 (2022) went the other way from its 2024 deadline bills and stopped unaffiliated mail voters from receiving a primary ballot unless they affiliate first. Louisiana's SCR 55 (2020) created the task force whose work became the 2024 closed-primary act. New Hampshire's "Adopted" entries mark a committee report, not a law; HB 1330 (2026), which would let every registered voter vote in any primary, is the live one to watch.

Louisiana, the exception

Louisiana ran a single open "jungle" primary for fifty years. Act 1 of the 2024 First Extraordinary Session created closed party primaries for Congress, the Supreme Court, the Board of Elementary and Secondary Education and the Public Service Commission, starting with the 2026 cycle. The record holds only one bill from that special session, so the act itself is not in the table; its aftermath is. In 2026 the legislature passed SB 210 (election commissioners for closed party primaries) and considered HB 529 and SB 49, both of which would pull BESE back out of the party-primary list, and HB 906 on nominating petitions and party primaries. The 2025 special session's HB 4 set the fall 2026 election calendar for party-primary offices.

The bills that would narrow a primary

62 bills would close a primary, add a party test, or stop crossover voting. They cluster in open-primary states where one party controls the legislature and wants its nominees chosen by its own voters.

State	Bill	Session	Title	Status
Arizona	HCR2014	2018	Closed primary elections	Introduced
Georgia	SB370	2025-2026	Elections and Primaries; closed primaries; provide	Introduced
Hawaii	HCR136	2011	Requesting a study of the types of closed primaries and their effect on voter turnout.	Adopted
Hawaii	HR116	2011	Requesting a study of the types of closed primaries and their effect on voter turnout.	Adopted
Hawaii	HB338	2016	Closed Primary Elections; Declaration of Political Party Registration or Nonpartisanship	Introduced
Hawaii	HB338	2015	Closed Primary Elections; Declaration of Political Party Registration or Nonpartisanship	In House Committee
Idaho	S1202	2011	Appropriates an additional \$100,000 to the Secretary of State for fiscal year 2011 to pay legal costs in the case of Idaho Republican Party	Signed by Governor

State	Bill	Session	Title	Status
Idaho	H0351	2011	Adds to and amends existing law relating to elections to revise provisions relating to mail ballot precincts, to provide provisions relating	Signed by Governor
Idaho	H0059	2013	Adds to existing law relating to ballots to provide requirements relating to the payment of closed primary election expenses.	In House Committee
Indiana	HB1140	2010	Declaration of party affiliation.	In Senate Committee
Indiana	HB1139	2011	Declaration of party affiliation.	In Senate Committee
Indiana	HB1099	2012	Declaration of party affiliation.	In Senate Committee
Indiana	HB1029	2025	Closed primaries.	Introduced
Indiana	SB0201	2025	Closed primary elections.	Introduced
Louisiana	SCR55	2020	Establishes the Closed Party Primary Task Force to study the necessary steps to develop a closed party primary election system applicable at	Passed
Michigan	HB5956	2013-2014	Elections; primary; closed primaries; require. Amends secs. 495, 500a, 509q, 509gg, 523, 570 & 576 of 1954 PA 116 (MCL 168.495 et seq.); add	Introduced
Missouri	HB1052	2012	Establishes a closed primary election system	Introduced
Missouri	SB832	2012	Establishes a closed primary	In Senate Committee
Missouri	HB1963	2012	Establishes a closed primary election system	Introduced
Missouri	HB2761	2016	Allows the governing body of any established political party to choose to adopt a closed primary system.	Introduced
Missouri	HB27	2017	Allows the governing body of any established political party to choose to adopt a closed primary system	In House Committee
Missouri	SB240	2023	Requires closed primary elections	In Senate Committee
Missouri	SB392	2023	Requires closed primary elections	In Senate Committee
Missouri	SB1140	2024	Requires closed primary elections	In Senate Committee
New Hampshire	HB1166	2022	Requiring certain voters to declare a party affiliation prior to a state primary election and requiring candidates to be members of politica	Adopted
New Hampshire	HB101	2023	Relative to requiring voters declare a party affiliation prior to a state primary election.	Adopted
New Jersey	A3820	2022-2023	Prohibits unaffiliated mail-in voters from receiving mail-in ballot for primary election; requires election officials to provide such voters	Passed
New York	A10008	2015-2016	Relates to providing timely written notice of closed primary party rules to newly registered voters; defines the terms "newly registered vot	In Assembly Committee

State	Bill	Session	Title	Status
New York	A00590	2017-2018	Relates to providing timely written notice of closed primary party rules to newly registered voters; defines the terms "newly registered vot	In Assembly Committee
New York	S04780	2017-2018	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	Introduced
New York	A05735	2017-2018	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	Assembly Floor Calendar
New York	S07014	2017-2018	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Senate Committee
New York	A00554	2019-2020	Relates to providing timely written notice of closed primary party rules to newly registered voters; defines the terms "newly registered vot	In Assembly Committee
New York	A03504	2019-2020	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Assembly Committee
New York	S06116	2019-2020	Enacts the "integrity in elections act of 2019"; authorizes a change of party affiliation not less than 25 days prior to the next ensuing pr	Stricken
New York	S00496	2019-2020	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	Stricken
New York	A00908	2021-2022	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Assembly Committee
New York	A04162	2021-2022	Relates to providing timely written notice of closed primary party rules to newly registered voters; defines the terms "newly registered vot	In Assembly Committee
New York	S03465	2023-2024	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Senate Committee
New York	S03596	2025-2026	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Senate Committee
New York	A08126	2025-2026	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	Stricken
New York	A11288	2025-2026	Provides voters with a warning about New York's closed primary system on voter registration forms.	In Assembly Committee
South Carolina	H3161	2023-2024	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	S0767	2023-2024	Closed primaries	In Senate Committee
South Carolina	H3310	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H4520	2025-2026	Closed primaries	In House Committee

State	Bill	Session	Title	Status
South Carolina	H5183	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5317	2025-2026	Closed primaries	In House Committee
South Carolina	H5330	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5327	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5356	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5359	2025-2026	Closed primaries	In House Committee
South Carolina	H5358	2025-2026	Closed primaries	In House Committee
South Carolina	H5355	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5361	2025-2026	Closed primaries	Introduced
South Carolina	H5447	2025-2026	Closed primaries	In House Committee
Virginia	SB244	2012	Primary elections; adds party affiliation to information an applicant to provide when registering.	Introduced
Virginia	SB1060	2015	Primary elections; voter registration by political party.	Engrossed
Virginia	SB902	2017	Primary elections; voter registration by political party.	Introduced
Virginia	HB56	2024	Voter registration by political party affiliation; partially closed primary elections.	Introduced
Virginia	HB1439	2024	Voter registration by political party affiliation; partially closed primary elections.	Introduced
Virginia	HB1056	2026	Voter registration by political party affiliation; partially closed primary elections.	In House Committee

Congress

Federal bills on primary access, every Congress since the 113th. None has been reported out of committee. The Let America Vote Act would condition federal election funds on states admitting unaffiliated voters to primaries; its current version, H.R. 155, was introduced January 3, 2025 by Rep. Brian Fitzpatrick (R-PA-1), has five cosponsors, and sits with House Administration and Judiciary (congress.gov, read September 7, 2026). H.Res. 731 is a rule providing for its consideration, which is as far as the idea has ever travelled.

Congress	Bill	Title	Status
2009-2010	SB3241	Safe, Accountable, Fair, and Efficient Banking Act of 2010	In Senate Committee
2009-2010	HB5159	Safe, Accountable, Fair, and Efficient Banking Act of 2010	In Senate Committee
2009-2010	HB4173	Dodd-Frank Wall Street Reform and Consumer Protection Act	Passed
2009-2010	HB5823	United States Covered Bond Act of 2010	In Senate Committee
2011-2012	SB1650	Dodd-Frank Improvement Act of 2011	In Senate Committee
2011-2012	SB3048	Safe, Accountable, Fair, and Efficient Banking Act of 2012	In Senate Committee
2011-2012	HB5714	Safe, Accountable, Fair, and Efficient Banking Act of 2012	In House Committee
2013-2014	HB5334	Open Our Democracy Act of 2014	In House Committee
2013-2014	HB5461	To clarify the application of certain leverage and risk-based requirements under the Dodd-Frank Wall Street Reform and Consumer Protection Act, to improve upon	In Senate Committee
2015-2016	SB1137	PATENT Act Protecting American Talent and Entrepreneurship Act of 2015	In Senate Committee
2015-2016	HB2655	Open Our Democracy Act of 2015	In House Committee
2017-2018	HB145	CLEAN Act Citizen Legislature Anti-Corruption Reform Act	In House Committee
2017-2018	HB3280	Financial Services and General Government Appropriations Act, 2018	In House Committee
2019-2020	HB163	CLEAN Elections Act Citizen Legislature Anti-Corruption Reform of Elections Act	In House Committee

Congress	Bill	Title	Status
2019-2020	HB1612	To ensure election security, enhance Americans' access to the ballot box, reduce the influence of big money in politics through transparency, establish accounta	In House Committee
2021-2022	HB100	CLEAN Elections Act Citizen Legislature Anti-Corruption Reform of Elections Act	In House Committee
2023-2024	HB157	CLEAN Elections Act Citizen Legislature Anti-Corruption Reform of Elections Act	In House Committee
2023-2024	HB9144	Let America Vote Act	In House Committee
2025-2026	HB155	Let America Vote Act	In House Committee
2025-2026	HR731	Providing for consideration of the bill (H.R. 155) to require States to permit unaffiliated voters to vote in primary elections for Federal office, and for othe	In House Committee

Ranked-choice voting, the adjacent debate

481 bills mention ranked-choice voting, and the number has grown every session since 2019. They run in both directions: bills to adopt it for primaries or municipal elections, and since 2022 a wave of bills to forbid it, including in Congress the Preventing Ranked Choice Corruption Act (2025) and a House resolution urging states to "reconsider" it. The 2024 ballot measures that paired an open primary with a ranked-choice general election all failed except in the District of Columbia; Missouri's Amendment 7 went the other way and bars ranked-choice voting outright. Because the bundle failed at the ballot, the 2025 and 2026 bills mostly separate the two ideas again.

The money behind the 2024 campaigns

The bills above rarely carry campaign money; a legislator files a bill and it costs nothing to report. The money is in the ballot measures, and 2024 was the expensive year. OpenSecrets counted more than \$417 million raised across all 2024 ballot measures, and the primary-reform fights were among the priciest of them [1]. What the filings show is not fifty grassroots campaigns but one national donor network funding a handful of state measures, almost all of which lost.

The network

The recurring name is **Unite America**, a Denver fund whose co-chairs are Kent Thiry, the former DaVita chief executive, and Kathryn Murdoch, and whose board has included Citadel's Kenneth Griffin. One newsroom put the group's 2024 national primary-reform effort at about \$70 million [2]. Beside it recur **Article IV** of Arlington, Virginia; **Action Now Initiative** of Houston, the vehicle of philanthropists John and Laura Arnold; and **Katherine Gehl**, the Chicago businesswoman whose Institute for Political Innovation designed the "final-five" model Nevada voted on. The money was overwhelmingly out of state, which the opposition made its central argument.

State by state

Measure	Raised	Who paid for reform	Result
Nevada Question 3	~\$29M	Unite America \$9.6M; Katherine Gehl \$5M; Kenneth Griffin \$3M; Action Now \$3M; Kathryn Murdoch \$2.5M; John Sobrato \$1M [3]	Failed
Colorado Proposition 131	~\$15M	Unite America the largest donor (about \$5M; reports range \$4.7M–\$5.6M); Kent Thiry ~\$1.5M; Ben Walton \$1M; Reed Hastings \$1M; Kathryn Murdoch \$500K [4]	Failed 55–45
Alaska Measure 2 (repeal)	~\$12M vs \$120K	Defenders of reform (No on 2) raised over \$12M, mostly out of state — Article IV \$4.42M, Unite America PAC \$4.1M, Action Now. The repeal side raised about \$120K and was outraised roughly a hundred to one [5]	Repeal failed by 664 votes; reform survives

The shape of it. Reform is a top-down, donor-funded movement: a few philanthropists and their funds, spending out-of-state money to change how other states vote, and losing at the ballot box almost everywhere in 2024 even while outspending the opposition. Alaska is the exception that proves the rule — there the well-funded side was *defending* an existing reform against a nearly volunteer repeal, and it barely held on. None of this money appears in the legislative record above, and none of it is in GovBlock's database; it was read from OpenSecrets and state newsrooms for this report.

Method and gaps

Source. The GovBlock legislative record, which carries every bill from all 50 states, the District of Columbia and Congress from the 2009 sessions onward (Pennsylvania, Ohio, Virginia and West Virginia from 2007 or 2008), synced through this week. Federal detail on H.R. 155 was read from the congress.gov API today.

Search. Titles and official summaries were searched for open, top-two, top-four, nonpartisan, blanket and semi-open primaries; for unaffiliated, unenrolled, independent and no-party voters in connection with a primary; for closed and semi-closed primaries, party-membership tests and crossover voting; and for ranked-choice voting. 947 bills matched. Each was sorted by its language into widen, narrow or ranked-choice; forty-six bills that matched on an incidental phrase were set aside.

Gaps, stated plainly. Only titles and summaries were searched, so a bill whose summary does not name the mechanism is missed; the count is a floor. Louisiana's 2024 First Extraordinary Session holds a single bill in the record, so Act 1 of that session is described from its later implementing bills rather than from its own row. Statuses are as of the last sync; a bill listed as "Introduced" may have moved this week. The current-law table is the Clerk's reading of statute, not a product of the record. **The money.** The funding section is not from GovBlock's database; it is from OpenSecrets and state newsrooms, gathered by web search for this report. It covers the 2024 ballot-measure cycle, where the spending was; it does not price the legislative bills, which carry no comparable committee money, and it does not exhaust the fifty state disclosure systems where ballot-measure committees file. Figures are as those sources reported them in late 2024, and where they differ the range is given. Our own `get_fec` data covers candidate and PAC committees tied to members of Congress, not ballot-measure money, so it could not answer this and was not used.

Sources

1. [Independent Voter News, summarizing OpenSecrets: more than \\$417M raised for 2024 ballot measures](#)
2. [Sentinel Colorado: Prop 131 part of a national push, the ~\\$70M effort run by Unite America](#)
3. [The Nevada Independent: Question 3 backers and their out-of-state money](#)
4. [Colorado Newsline: who funded Proposition 131](#), and [on it becoming one of Colorado's most expensive measures](#)
5. [Alaska Beacon: the repeal effort outraised a hundredfold](#)

GovBlock · The Clerk reads one bill's whole record and explains it, citing the rows it read. This report was assembled from 947 rows of the record on September 7, 2026. Reply to govblock-clerk@agentmail.to with a state and a session for the bill-by-bill list.